

CSCW Contributions to Critical Futures of Work

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Abstract

As the CSCW community evolves and participates in envisioning the impact of technologies on the work practices, we want to ensure that critical and alternative computing perspectives are well represented while we are co-constructing the future of work. In this hybrid workshop, we invite researchers, practitioners, civic actors, economists, and other interested parties to challenge dominant, powerful, status-quo narratives and imaginaries when considering the future of work, nurturing the CSCW commitments and methods. Co-constructing the workshop with participants, we aim to develop actionable insights and strengthen the community.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → HCI theory, concepts and models; **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; **Collaborative and social computing theory, concepts and paradigms**.

Keywords

CSCW, Future of work, Critical computing, Workers, Labor, Diversity, Pluralism

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1 Motivation

The CSCW community has been consistently sensitive to work processes and labor conditions [20, 77, 84], considerate of tensions around (in)visibility of work [83], careful in the examination of new [25, 27, 76, 97] and evolving forms of labor due to technological

changes [66, 96], as well as novel work configurations [30]. Scholarly works such as those cited in [18, 22, 44, 45, 56] underscore the critical need to examine how cooperative approaches to technology can foster a fairer, more sustainable, and flourishing society. *Based on this, how might we define the relationship between Critical Computing and CSCW?*

Once we switch from examining existing practices to scanning the horizon for future of work visions, however, the prevalent visions often overshadow alternative narratives and marginalized voices, perpetuating a uni-vocal status quo that may not serve the broader interests of workers and other stakeholders [19, 21, 51, 55, 65, 91]. This power imbalance can be embodied in dominant imaginaries, narratives propelled by powerful industry, or state players [1, 17], versus counter-imaginaries — imaginaries re-appropriated by civic actors, or their alternatives [10, 47, 96]. Often, conventional accounts propose a *single hegemonic future vision* (e.g., [31, 93]), crowding-out the ideas of less powerful constituencies. In this workshop, we aim to develop alternative visions as co-existing, mutually-informative *versions* of possible futures (see, e.g., [9, 16, 50, 56, 71, 82]), building and expanding on the major themes of CSCW, such as work [77], labor [84], articulation work [85], awareness [38, 78], coordination [38], flexibility [13], and Feminism [6, 70, 83, 94]. We share below our epistemic and social convictions to pay attention to worker and particularly women voices.

Workers' Voices. Excluding worker voices and voices of labor [19, 49] in decisions about technological advancements and workplace policies can lead to outcomes that disproportionately benefit employers [17]. Without input from those directly affected by these changes, workers, policies and technologies may fail to address the real needs of the workforce, exacerbating existing inequalities and injustices.

Women's Voices. We focus on the voices of women as members of labor [33, 34, 64], and as a distinct interest group that intersects with labor [7, 9, 26]. Excluding them in the design of work and work technologies can perpetuate biases and inequitable outcomes. Feminist analysis and advocacy have addressed these gaps [7], but inequalities remain (e.g., [25, 40]). Without direct participation of and representation by women, the design of work and work

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technologies is likely to invisibilize women employees as a class, further reducing their bargaining power and livelihoods [52, 92].

Potential Consequences of Exclusion.

- (1) Technologies designed without worker input can result in tools that are not only user-unfriendly but also fail to meaningfully support work practices [67]: overly automated systems might reduce job satisfaction or even eliminate positions [79], without offering viable alternatives or retraining opportunities [8]. Echoing the resolution of the post-growth HCI movement [81], we invite the community to shift the focus from economically viable productivity towards solidarity [43].
- (2) Policies crafted without considering the diverse experiences of workers might not accommodate varying needs, leading to a one-size-fits-all approach that actually fits very few. This could manifest in inflexible work hours, inadequate safety measures, or unfair compensation structures that further marginalize part-time gig workers [28, 61, 64, 75].
- (3) Global companies might implement policies that are culturally insensitive or inapplicable across different geographical locations, failing to account for local labor laws, cultural norms, or economic conditions [89].

Excluding workers from decision-making has historically led to exploitative labor systems, as seen in company stores and debt peonage across Australia, Mexico, Nicaragua, Peru, the Philippines, and the United States [11, 14, 23, 29, 48, 53, 57, 59]. Lacking agency, workers were trapped in cycles of debt and dependency [60], reinforcing employer control and company profits [15]. For example, during the Porfiriato in Mexico and early industrial United States, workers were paid in vouchers redeemable only at *company stores* [5, 53], depriving them of financial independence [46]. These exploitative structures persisted precisely because workers had no voice, fueling unrest and eventually driving labor reforms [73, 90]. Without hearing workers voices, systems risk perpetuating exploitation, whereas worker-centered decision-making fosters fair and sustainable labor conditions [12].

Møller et al. [62] describe a contemporary case in which medical secretaries were assumed to be unnecessary after the introduction of a new record-keeping system. However, the nature of the secretaries' work changed, but was just as important as before the new system. This is also an example of the convergence of worker's and women's issues - i.e., technologists' imaginaries tend to make both groups invisible and unheard (see also [83]).

Global Implications. The failure to incorporate workers' and women's input can lead to similar disparities: rapid technological advances in places like India and China have transformed industries but also caused significant disruptions in traditional jobs [69, 92]. Without adequate worker engagement, the transition can result in massive displacement without sufficient economic safety nets or re-skilling opportunities.

Need for a Dedicated Workshop

This proposed workshop at CSCW is designed to champion the pluralities of visions for the future of work, emphasizing the importance of diverse voices and perspectives in shaping these narratives.

By focusing on feminist [4, 9, 19, 40], labor [1, 21, 42, 56, 87, 88], colonialism-informed [1, 21, 24, 40, 63, 65] approaches, platformization experiences [2, 28, 36, 75, 80], surveillance and counter-measures [37, 54, 58, 74, 75, 86], and other methods of centering workers — such as Participatory Design (PD) [32] — we can ensure a more inclusive discourse that considers a wide range of impacts on different types of workers, from office employees to gig workers.

We build on previous efforts that explored the relationship of workplaces, platformization, and on-demand work [44]; renewed attention to labor perspectives in studies of future of work [87]; re-engagement with “governance, privacy, trust, and transparency” in collaboration with labor groups [42, ms p.1]; worker well-being in future work technologies [39] and the possibilities for radical politics of care in future work [45, 96]; and sociotechnical challenges of hybrid work during the Covid pandemic [30], as well as a panel on the roles and responsibilities of researchers exploring the future of work [35]. Two workshops come close to our proposal: Lindley et al. [56] and Cheon et al. [18] called for studies of modes of labor and political economy in relation to changing modes of work, automation, human-computer collaboration, temporal patterns of work, and sites of work. Since those workshops, we have experienced a partial, *mandated* “return to work” [68], the increasing platformization of gig workers and gig work [75, 89], and renewed threats to skills and jobs from AI innovations [50, 72, 95]. Six years after Lindley et al. and four years after Cheon et al., we believe it is time for renewed *pluralistic* critical interrogations of the future of work.

Objectives

- **Encourage Diverse Approaches:** Break away from the often technocentric views that dominate our discourse on the future of work.
- **Foster Critical Engagement:** Critically examine how current and emerging technologies influence work practices and worker well-being.
- **Develop Actionable Insights:** Guide policymakers, technologists, and business leaders in creating equitable work environments.
- **Strengthen Community:** Continue to gather and facilitate scholars of CSCW and Critical and Sustainable Computing and Social Justice in relation to the future of work.

Positioning ourselves on the crossroads of Critical Computing and CSCW, we feel responsible to “engage in creative forms of action to address” the ongoing polycrisis [41, ms p.5] [43].

2 Workshop Mode

The workshop will operate in a hybrid mode, combining in-person and virtual participation, to maximize accessibility and engagement, following sociotechnical hybrid-conference practices described by Ansah et al. [3]. The hybrid commitments of the workshop will tend toward online-compatible presentations and break-out groups; we hope to work with accepted authors on more creative, hybrid-effective ways to engage our mixed participants. We hope to ensure that all voices, especially those often marginalized in technology discussions, can contribute meaningfully. We will accept up to 20 participants.

Table 1: Draft Schedule for the Workshop

Time	Activity
9:00-9:15	Introductions and Expectations
9:15-10:00	Keynote presentation ^a + discussion
10:00-10:30	1st panel of presentations + brief discussion
10:30-11:00	Break
11:00-12:30	2nd, 3rd, 4th panels + brief discussions
12:30-2:00	Lunch
2:00-3:30	Break-out group discussions ^b
3:30-4:00	Break
4:00-5:00	Plenary discussions
5:00-5:30	Next steps + Goodbye

Notes:

a. One or two keynote talks will be invited from among the submissions.

b. We may hold some break-out groups in Zoom rooms.

Communication Environment: We will use a dedicated workshop website as the central hub for all information, updates, and resources, Slack for backchannel communication, and a videoconferencing software to support the remote and in-person presence.

Inclusivity and Engagement: Each session will be designed to be inclusive, with moderators ensuring that all participants, whether attending in person or virtually, have the opportunity to contribute (e.g., [3]). We will ask the participants about their accessibility needs. We may contact the Accessibility Chairs for advice if needed. Responsible for remote-engagement technologies, we will limit our requests to advice, not resources.

2.1 Pre-Workshop Plans

To ensure that the workshop is participatory, inclusive, and grounded in diverse perspectives, we will implement a series of structured activities before the event:

(1) Community Setup

Once participants are accepted, we will invite them to join a dedicated Slack workspace. We will also circulate a welcome packet that includes:

- Information about the workshop goals and values, organizers and participants
- Accessibility guidelines
- Key readings and provocations to spark discussion
- Optional creative prompts (e.g., imagining “a day at work in 2040”)

(2) Gathering Pre-Workshop Contributions

Participants will be encouraged to submit a short position piece or artifact (e.g., text, artwork, video, or design fiction) that reflects their perspective on the future of work. These contributions will:

- Be displayed on the workshop website
- Serve as grounding material for breakout sessions
- Enable participants to get to know each other’s work and interests in advance

We will also invite participants to co-shape the agenda by proposing topics or formats for interactive sessions. This co-construction supports our goal of decentralizing authority and ensuring the workshop reflects the collective values of the group.

(3) Pre-Workshop Social Gathering (Optional)

To foster early community-building, we will host a casual virtual gathering 1–2 weeks before the workshop. This will serve as an opportunity for participants to introduce themselves, build rapport and discuss early ideas in a low-pressure setting.

(4) Accessibility and Inclusion Planning

We will survey participants in advance to understand accessibility needs, time zone constraints, and language preferences, and we will coordinate with CSCW’s Accessibility Chairs as needed.

3 Draft of the Call for Participation

We invite academics, industry professionals, policymakers, freelance workers, civic actors, activists, economists, and other interested parties to participate in our upcoming one-day hybrid workshop, “CSCW Contributions to Critical Futures of Work.”

Workshop Themes: The workshop will explore innovative ways to integrate diverse and often marginalized voices into the design and implementation of work technologies. We are particularly interested in contributions that address:

- **The impact of recent technologies and configurations on future labor practices.** What responses can the CSCSW community make to the new pressures to commoditize work and to silence workers, including AI displacements of human labor?
- **Feminist, post-colonial, post-growth critiques of current work technologies.** How do these frameworks support us in resisting the dominant imaginaries? How can we ground our future visions in the CSCW traditions of pluralistic inquiry?
- **Strategies for inclusively designing future work and workplaces.** Acknowledging that inequalities (patriarchy, racism, colonialism) are not overcome, how do we protect the discriminated workers from the power abuses?

Workshop Outputs: As a key outcome of the workshop, we aim to generate tangible, community-driven outputs that reflect the diverse insights and collaborative efforts of participants:

- A living repository featuring:
 - Participant contributions
 - Key discussion takeaways
 - A synthesis of alternative imaginaries for the future of work
- A community-authored report or manifesto highlighting critical design principles and strategies for building inclusive, worker-centered technologies
- Seed ideas for future collaborative research projects, papers, or grant proposals
- A shared communication space (e.g., Slack or mailing list) to continue conversations, collaborations, and knowledge exchange beyond the workshop

Measuring Success: To evaluate the success of the workshop, we will use qualitative and quantitative indicators:

- Level of interaction in breakout sessions, number of submitted artifacts, and active contributions during discussions (in-person and virtual)
- Representation of participants from varied regions, professions, and social positions, particularly those from traditionally marginalized or underrepresented communities
- Depth of reflection and innovation in the contributions created and shared during the workshop
- Follow-up collaborations, citations of workshop outputs, and continued use of the materials or principles developed
- Surveys and informal reflections to assess satisfaction, perceived value, and suggestions for improvement

Participation: We invite the participants to co-construct the workshop agenda. We encourage proposals for presentations, panel discussions, and interactive sessions that align with the theme of critical computing for the future of work. We also welcome alternative forms of submissions, such as pictorials, art pieces, design fictions, glossaries, research proposals, multimedia presentations, and other creative media that express ideas and perspectives on the topic. Proposals should aim to highlight the role of diverse voices in shaping futures of work and may focus on empirical research, theoretical frameworks, or innovative artistic expressions. We plan to publish the accepted contributions on the workshop website. We will guide the participants to achieve tangible outcomes as a result of the workshop. CSCW requires that at least one author of each accepted submission attend the workshop and register for at least one day of the conference.

Format: The workshop will operate in a hybrid mode, accommodating both in-person and remote participants. A dedicated website (<https://tinyurl.com/criticalfuturesofwork>) and Slack channel will support ongoing dialogue and resource sharing.

Submission Guidelines: Please submit an abstract of up to 500 words or your proposed research, artistic, or multimedia contribution via the workshop website by August 11th, 2025.

Join us as we challenge traditional narratives and work together to ensure that the future of work is equitable, sustainable, and inclusive.

4 Workshop Organizers and Their Roles

- **Alina Lushnikova** is a PhD student at the University of Luxembourg. Her research is focused on exploring hybrid work imaginaries and supporting well-being in the workplace. Alina will maintain a focus on pluralistic visions of future work, informed by workers' needs for work that preserves human dignity.
- **Michael Muller** works at IBM Research in Cambridge MA USA, where he focuses on human-AI collaboration and co-creativity. He has (co-)organized successful workshops at CHI, CSCW, DIS, GROUP, and NeurIPS. Michael will help design and moderate interactive sessions that explore pluralistic visions of collaborative AI systems.
- **Shaowen Bardzell** is a Professor in the School of Interactive Computing at Georgia Institute of Technology. A common

thread throughout her work is the exploration of the contributions of Feminism, design, and social science to support technology's role in social change. Shaowen will lead discussions on feminist and post-colonial perspectives in shaping the future of work. She will help guide participants in exploring critical and pluralist imaginaries, challenging dominant narratives, and supporting marginalized communities through design methodologies.

- **Toby Li** is an Assistant Professor of Computer Science and Engineering and the Director of the Human-Centered Responsible AI Lab in the Lucy Family Institute for Data & Society at the University of Notre Dame. His recent work seeks to address the societal challenges in the future of work through a bottom-up human-AI collaborative approach that helps individual workers automate and augment their tasks with AI systems. Toby will focus on sessions that explore bottom-up human-AI collaboration and how AI can be used to support rather than replace workers, aligning AI systems with the ethics of everyday work practices, especially via worker-augmented automation.

- **Saiph Savage** is an Assistant Professor at Northeastern University and also collaborates with the Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México (UNAM). Her research focuses on creating methods that allow workers to collaboratively design their own technology solutions, facilitating collective actions from start to finish.

With her background in worker-led technology design and collective action, Saiph will facilitate co-design sessions that center worker agency and empowerment. She will guide participatory activities to explore how civic actors and workers can co-create tools that challenge exploitative labor structures and promote justice.

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